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The Online Community Obsessed With a CIA Puzzle

Kryptos, a sculpture at the agency's headquarters bearing a secret message in code, continues to inspire a diverse group of sleuths after three decades.



Kryptos, 20 feet long and 12 feet high, stands in a courtyard at CIA headquarters.

PHOTO: JIM SANBORN

By *A.J. Jacobs*

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I have infiltrated CIA headquarters in Langley, Va., on a top-secret mission.

Okay, “infiltrate” might be an exaggeration. I spent several weeks getting permission from the CIA media relations department. I underwent a thorough background check. I am accompanied by several CIA officers at all times. So I’m not quite Jason Bourne.

Still, I have made it inside CIA headquarters, and I am, in fact, on a mission. I’m on a quest to decode Kryptos, one of the most famous unsolved puzzles in the world. In 1988, the CIA commissioned Maryland-based artist Jim Sanborn to create a sculpture for its

expanding headquarters. The agency wanted to install some art that would be relevant to its mission of cracking secrets.

More than 30 years later, the code has not been fully cracked, even by the CIA itself.

The main part of Kryptos is a wavy wall of copper about 20 feet long and 12 feet high. Into the copper, Mr. Sanborn has carved about 1,800 seemingly random letters and four question marks. It's a code, a secret message. No one knows the solution except Mr. Sanborn and possibly a former director of the CIA. Kryptos was dedicated in 1990; more than 30 years later, the code has not been fully cracked, even by the CIA itself.

Granted, it has been partially cracked. In the 1990s, amateurs and CIA staffers independently solved three of the four sections. When decoded, the first section of the sculpture contains a mysterious sentence from Mr. Sanborn about "subtle shading and the nuance of illusion." The second section contains what seem to be GPS coordinates and hints that something is buried. The third section is a paraphrase of archaeologist Howard Carter describing his experience in 1922 of peering through an opening to discover King Tut's tomb.

But the fourth section, called K4 by fans, remains opaque. Over the last 10 years, Mr. Sanborn has given tantalizing hints, revealing that K4 contains the words "northeast," "Berlin," and "clock." But so far it remains unbroken. It's just 97 letters, but they are perhaps the most exasperating 97 letters ever written.



Sculptor Jim Sanborn, seen here in 2003, was commissioned to create Kryptos in 1988 and still fields questions from would-be solvers.

PHOTO: THE WASHINGTON TIMES/ZUMA PRESS

A few months ago, I joined an online community of thousands of Kryptos obsessives. Several times a week, I get messages about the latest theories. Maybe the code is related to Egyptian hieroglyphics? Or Dante's "Inferno"? The theories are endless and endlessly creative.

There's also speculation about what comes after K4. Mr. Sanborn has said that even after all the sculpture's codes are solved, there will still be a further mystery. Perhaps a buried treasure? A combination to a safe? No one knows.

Mr. Sanborn is clever, but what I really love about the Kryptos phenomenon is the tenacity of the solvers. They're still going at it 30 years later. It's a diverse group—computer scientists, artists, doctors, professional cryptographers—all united by this quest. What grit! Well, some might call it an unhealthy obsession. But I prefer to see it as grit.

Before my field trip, I post a message to the Kryptos community asking what they want me to look for. I get a barrage of requests: Bring a compass and see if it behaves oddly. Look for any shadows that are cast on the sculpture. Look for weird markings on its bottom. Peer inside any nearby holes.

On a summer Saturday, armed with my list, I pass through security and enter the CIA's main office building. It turns out that it's a bit of a hike to get to Kryptos. The Langley compound is huge and surprisingly serene. There are lawns, elms and a koi pond. If not for the helicopter from the war in Afghanistan displayed near the parking lot, it might be mistaken for a high-end college campus.

We finally arrive at some glass doors that lead to a courtyard with red patio tables and chairs. And there it is, in all its frustrating glory: Kryptos. It's smaller than I expected. In my mind, I had somehow built it up to rival Stonehenge. But it's also prettier than I expected. The sculpture's undulating shape is almost relaxing, and the copper's oxidized green tinge makes it stately. "Can I touch it?" I ask.

SHARE YOUR THOUGHTS

What kinds of puzzles do you enjoy trying to solve? Join the conversation below.

My tour guide—the CIA historian Randy Burkett, friendly but straitlaced, in a black suit—nods yes. I run my hand over the carved-out letters. The copper is cold, despite the warmth of the day.

Maybe it will relinquish its secrets to my touch, like when Spock puts his hands over someone's face. Sadly, there is no rush of images to my brain.

Before my Langley visit, I emailed Jim Sanborn, and he agreed to an interview. I was worried he'd be cranky, but he actually seemed open to talking—at least to a point. Creating Kryptos wasn't easy, he says. He had to get lessons in cryptology from a retiring CIA agent. As for the sculpting itself, "I went through 15 different assistants, 900 jigsaw blades and 12 Bosch jigsaws over two and a half years," Mr. Sanborn

says.

Thirty years on, he has mixed feelings about his most famous work. On the one hand, he gets annoyed at the thousands of people pestering him for clues or hints—some of them politely, some not so much. “I got threatening mail, threatening phone calls, weird packages left at my front porch that I had to open almost robotically,” he says. On the other hand, he’s grateful that Kryptos continues to fascinate: “Frankly, the greatest satisfaction I get is that I have created an artwork which keeps on giving.”

After my visit to the CIA, I post my observations on the Kryptos message board. They are deeply arcane, but that’s the point. I write about the whirlpool abutting the sculpture, my compass going crazy when placed on a nearby magnetic stone, and the position of the bolts that run through the middle of Kryptos.

I get a bunch of emails back. Overall, the community is thankful, but they have more questions. Did the whirlpool swirl clockwise, or were the waves random? Do you think there could be a speaker or microphone hidden inside the drain, the metal box or the hole in the granite? I don’t have the answers. I did my best, but I obviously didn’t observe closely enough.

I decide to contact Mr. Sanborn one final time. It should be noted that he’s not just a talented artist, he’s also an astute businessman. A few years ago, he got annoyed that he was wasting so much time responding to emailed guesses, so he instituted a new rule. You can send him a guess, and he will send you a short response telling you if you’re right or wrong. For that, you pay him \$50.

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I’m jealous. Fifty bucks for a sentence or two. That’s an enviable rate for a writer. Others in the Kryptos community aren’t fans of the \$50 charge. On the message board, some K4 solvers call this rule “tacky” and accuse Mr. Sanborn of a scam.

I send in \$50 via PayPal and submit my guess, which is just that—a guess. My method was more impressionistic than scientific: I tried to enter the mind of Jim Sanborn and come up with something in his

voice. My guess is: “Took you long enough. Two steps Northeast of the coordinates. Face 7 p.m. on Berlin clock. Walk 12 steps. Dig. Enjoy!” I see it as a lottery ticket, a 1 in 4 billion chance these are the right letters.

A few days later, I got my answer. Jim thanked me for the money, but “unfortunately it’s not the decrypt.” Not the wisest \$50 I’ve spent in my life, but it felt oddly satisfying to take my shot.

—This essay is adapted from Mr. Jacobs’s new book, “*The Puzzler: One Man’s Quest to Solve the Most Baffling Puzzles Ever, from Crosswords to Jigsaws to the Meaning of Life*,” which will be published by Crown on April 26.

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